ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

UTTAR PRADESH

# SPOKES IN THE WHEEL



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

**JUMPING SHIP** Aparna Yadav with Yogi Adityanath and J.P. Nadda

Last week, the Samajwadi camp had been buoyed by desertions from the BJP. Its turn to suffer some jitters was bound to come. On January 19, Aparna Yadav, the second daughter-in-law of party founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, did the honours by waltzing across the political divide to join the BJP. Even if SP circles downplayed the significance of her exit—hinting at thwarted ambition and a ticket that wasn't—it gives the BJP a chance to spin the narrative of a "rift" in the Yadav parivar. Married to Prateek Yadav, Mulayam's "stepson" via second wife Sadhna Gupta, Aparna is a Thakur-Bisht like current CM Yogi Adityanath. A proximity to the right has often been ascribed to her, so the loss is more in terms of optics.

Less than happy vibes came from another quarters. After talks over seats broke down, Bhim Army chief Chandrashekhar Azad distanced himself from the SP alliance. Akhilesh Yadav apparently offered Azad only two seats, while he wanted 10—and a middle ground proved elusive. "I felt Akhileshji doesn't want Dalit leaders, only Dalit votes," said Azad. The Bhim Army's ground strength may be more modest than Azad's iconic stature suggests, but the optics here is more damaging in real terms.

Kumar onwards has employed with success. Just upgrade from a free cycle to a free scooty, and a mobile phone, itself a marker of freedom for young women in rural India.

That's a lot of virtue-signalling, but what purchase will it have in cynical, hard-bitten UP? "We have only one MP and seven MLAs here. We can only gain, there's nothing to lose," says a senior Congress leader. "Our vote share in 2017 was only 6.25 per cent. Now we have created a parallel narrative around '*aadhi aabadi*'—half the population. If we succeed even partially in attracting them, we would have established ourselves in almost every assembly constituency, something we have not done in years." Says a key member of Priyanka's team, "We have divided UP's 403 seats into three categories—'A' is where we have sitting MLAs or which we won either in 2012 or 2007; 'B' is all the seats where we were runners-up in 2017 and 2012; and in 'C', we put the rest of the seats where we can give tickets to freshers/ beginners. We are not cancelling tickets for any deserving male candidate just to accommodate women."

All this goes with a direct call to action. The motto '*Ladki Hoon, Lad Sakti Hoon*' (I am a woman, I can fight) was born after Priyanka met the Unnao rape victim, who said she would never lose hope in her fight against her oppressors. After that, Priyanka decided to link up with other victim families, activists and social workers, motivating them to come into politics. The candidates echo the sentiments. Says Jafar, who got a ticket from Lucknow (Central): "Priyankaji has met so many women like us who have seen real struggle. When I was in jail, beaten and threatened, she came in my support. Her team helps me with legal issues." Says Pankhuri Pathak, who goes up against Rajnath Singh's sitting MLA-son Pankaj Singh from Noida: "They consider it a safe seat... the SP-BSP never put up strong candidates. Now a young woman will challenge him. The kind of confidence it gives is immense."

Scholars feel the Congress has done something that will have a positive spinoff all around. Says Dr Tarushikha Sarvesh of the Advanced Centre for Women's Studies, AMU: "Earlier, parties gave only token representation. This creates hope of changing society's thinking about women in leadership roles—as more than an aberration. It will affect other parties too in the future." Dr Shilp Shikha Singh of the Giri Institute of Development Studies, Lucknow, agrees. "This can change the political discourse beyond UP. It may not bring a significant seat gain for the Congress, but will definitely increase its vote share." Priyanka's team member puts it thus: "Modi once called women the BJP's silent voters. We are hoping they become our vocal voters." ■

## A GENDERED APPROACH

The Congress sets its eyes on the other half of the population

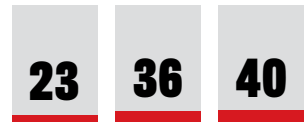
**150 million** Total number of voters in UP



**69.8 million** Total no. of women voters

### WINS BY WOMEN MLAs

TOTAL SEATS **403**




### CONGRESS SEATS

Vote share in ( )

